

Medst 341W – Film Theory Video Analysis
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Cinema and Sensation

Jordan Schonig's [Intro to Phenomenology and Vivian Sobchack's Film Theory](#) examines basic phenomenological principles, introduces the philosophers who espoused phenomenological perspectives, and ties phenomenology into film theory via Vivian Sobchack's "What My Fingers Knew". Phenomenology as a philosophy considers an individual's perception and experience of the world and seeks to describe the nature of things as they are experienced by that individual, rather than seeking to quantify or qualify from an objective scientific perspective. The very word itself is derived from the root word "phenomena", which concerns itself with appearances and observations and things "known through the senses"¹. Unlike scientists, the phenomenologist's aim is not to discover the "true" nature of anything, rather it is to study and examine the structures of "experience and consciousness" – Schonig places great emphasis on the inclusion of "structure", as phenomenology is not a simple matter of observable impressions of the world in as much as it is preoccupied with the common structures between individual experience and perspective. Contributions to this philosophical study came from Edmund Husserl and his student Martin Heidegger, Jean-Paul Sartre, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, and Simone de Beauvoir, who all published books relating to phenomenology in their respective time periods. Husserl (circa early 20th century) was concerned with how our minds fill in the "gaps" of things not directly observed, while Heidegger examined the idea of tools and how they only enter our consciousness when they "perform" and how some objects change in appearance based on circumstance. Sartre's existentialist philosophy (circa 1940s) overlapped with

¹ <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/phenomenon>

phenomenology, and he collaborated with de Beauvoir, a feminist, as both had similar philosophical ideas in terms of perception and experience. Ultimately Schonig draws primarily from French philosopher Merleau-Ponty (*Phenomenology of Perception*, 1945), who considered the Gestalt psychology emphasis on perception and significance of “wholes versus parts” as relevant to phenomenology and whose work is foundational for Sobchack’s essay.

Most generally, phenomenology first attempts to address the “aspects of the given”, or aspects of life that we anticipate without active consideration or awareness (Schonig calls it the “background” of experience). This backdrop is comprised of things not actively perceived until one consciously considers them, such as sensory impressions of one’s physical weight upon a surface or upon the ground or the innate, automatic anticipation of another world existing on the other side of a door’s threshold as one steps outside their house. Another focus of phenomenologists is the relationship between the whole and its constituent parts; per Gestalt psychology, we have a natural inclination to perceive things as whole objects (gestalt itself means “whole” or “form”), not discrete parts, and the whole forms become more than simply the sum of the parts. Optical illusions such as those emphasizing illusory contours (i.e. multistability, in which an item may look like two black vases or two white facial profiles, or reification, in which a series of spikes surrounding a round negative space cause the eye to see a ball with spikes, rather than disembodied spikes) underscore the phenomenological notion of this common structure of experience – we subconsciously fill in the empty space to see wholes when we are only given parts. Schonig also notes that this experience applies to time; we do not experience time meaningfully in fragments of seconds or minutes, but as a whole experience, subject to psychological temporal distortion. He uses a song melody as an example, as we never hear the individual notes playing in a melody, but we hear the whole, and sometimes can anticipate the

next note; memory, anticipation, and sensation combine to create a larger experience than simply hearing a series of consecutive, discrete musical notes.

Another aspect of phenomenology is that it considers aspects of experience to be pre-reflective, rather than reflective. For example, when one plays a sport, the body automatically catches a ball or has a sort of “muscle memory” that precludes any reflective attempt to consciously act. It is an embodied thinking that precludes awareness, or, more simply, it is habit; Merleau-Ponty considered habit to be “knowledge in the hands” - the body knows things independently of conscious reasoning. This view of the body also considers the relationship of the “five senses” and their construction of experience and perception as a whole dynamic of input rather than discrete sensory input. This is where phenomenology can apply to film theory; Sobchack quotes Merleau-Ponty in her essay: “The form of objects is not their geometrical shape: it stands in a certain relation to their specific nature, it appeals to our other senses as well as sight. The form of a fold in linen or cotton shows us the resilience or dryness of the fiber, the coldness or warmth of the material...In the jerk of the twig from which a bird has just flown, we read its flexibility or elasticity...One sees the weight of a block of cast iron which sinks in the sand, the fluidity of water and the viscosity of syrup.” (Sobchack 71). In essence, we can actively distinguish between the five senses, but this cognitive awareness of their distinctness doesn’t work in practice – sight, for example, as one watches a film can evoke the other senses (as part of that pre-reflective embodied thinking). Schonig calls it “feeling with your eyes”, as we experience multiple senses through the other senses. When we see a texture onscreen, we can “feel” the texture, or when we see something odorous, slippery, hot, etc, the mind fills in the gaps of actually experiencing it firsthand and activates multiple senses beyond just seeing.

Phenomenology is also not concerned with measurement, explanation, or analysis; unlike

other philosophies or even other film theories, it posits that human experience should be described with particular attention to nuance and pre-reflective experience. Where science describes objects in objective, measurable terms or seeks to understand the true nature of things, phenomenology simply wants to describe things as they appear to us or as we experience them, separate from our “natural attitude” i.e. common assumptions and assumed certainties which can often obscure the subjectivity of the human experience. Overall, phenomenology provides that things already exist, and the materiality of an object is implicitly understood and irrelevant to the perception of it. The established materiality of science is often not consistent with experience, and Schonig uses the optical illusion of two lines that appear to be different lengths (one is bracketed with outward facing arrows, while the other is bracketed with inward facing arrows) to demonstrate this incongruity. Despite casual observation showing two different lengths of line, when measured scientifically, the lines are the same exact length. Objectively, science says the lines are equal, but when observed pre-reflectively, one’s experience or sensation immediately *feels* that one line is shorter than the other. This disinterest in explanation and analysis leads, inevitably, to a disinterest in interpretation and avoidance of wallowing in symbolism. As it applies to film, Schonig references Susan Sontag’s “Against Interpretation” – by fervently seeking to interpret a film’s symbols or meaning, we lose sight of the nuanced response to art, miss the immediate experience of “feeling” it, and ignore the subjective proximity to a film’s content or imagery. Sobchack also comments upon this in regards to a film critic’s emphasis on objectivity: “One senses that her bodily reference is derived less from tactile foresight than from visual hindsight...Jacobs objectifies the side of touch far too quickly -- rushing to reduce vision to a point of view, hurrying to consider tactility and fingers and hands in terms of their narrative symbolism.” (Sobchack 64). Again, phenomenology in film is more concerned with the sensory

aspect, the interplay between senses, the feelings and sensations conjured by images, the pre-reflective responses, anticipation, and habits we might otherwise not notice during the course of life, and the awareness of how we might engage with a film through the senses and automatically evoked emotions. Unlike other theories that seek to establish meaning or identify some concrete thread or element that consistently binds a movement, phenomenology in film is completely preoccupied with the individual responses to art – not the reflective, conscious, or interpretive responses, but the ones that generate a multitude of personal sensation, relative to one's background, contrary to “natural attitudes”, as these are the gaps in human experience that science and rigid theory tend to overlook in favor of facts, analysis, and qualitative / quantitative measurability. “Meaning” in this case is a product of Schonig's “structures of perception and consciousness”; ultimately, it implies that film and art don't have innate meaning or wholeness until we participate, imbuing subjective meanings through our sensory and subconscious experience of the world.

In regards to the video essay itself, if one considers the “traditional” university approach as (very generally) a lecture and accompanying media slideshow (although depends on when one attended university - long-gone are the hastily scribbled concept maps or mind maps scattered across a chalkboard), then this format is comparable in terms of relaying knowledge and breaking down components of theory into digestible aspects of history, definition, application, and modern examples, although the absence of interactive participation puts it at a disadvantage. I prefer organic classroom discussion, as it provides unscripted opportunities for deeper explanation and alternative perspectives, or it engenders off the cuff examples that are influenced by a professor's experience or psyche on that particular day; it creates an emotional response around the topic versus the controlled, staged, and highly edited aspect of a pre-recorded video

essay. The dynamic nature of human moods, intricacies of communication, and subtle impact of our environment can influence a lecture; in phenomenological terms, the “audience participation”, “world-building” and subjective experience play a role in whether a lecture - regardless of its objective content - is intense or boring, punctuated by tangents or straight and narrow, poorly or highly received (and creating a feedback loop), or taken profoundly to heart. In phenomenology, the whole *is* greater than its parts; a particular cohort combined with a particular professor and topic can feel larger or smaller than reality in terms of impact and engagement. For example, there are times that our class readings alone do not provide the dimensional experience of a lecture given by a passionate and knowledgeable expert who is able to translate lofty philosophical content into a language that their particular classroom can grasp (with bonus pop culture references) - the video essay is similar to the class reading in that it is one-sided, the process of creation is already over by the time we are watching it, and there is no diversion or risk of participatory viewer influence. Overall it lacks the improvisational qualities of a traditional lecture and the organic classroom culture that springs forth from the particular body of students who compose that class - objective reality does not exist in any meaningful way without the interaction of the diverse psychologies of humanity, and learning involves the experience of learning as much as absorbing and understanding content. Additionally, for this particular essay, I struggled with the topical “jumping around”; in lecture (not all lectures, but ours in particular), there is a clear progression of historical origin, development of theory, and application to film – this video jumps around very quickly in a manner that is difficult for me to follow (perhaps it is just me; I require a great deal of structure and emphatic silence to “digest” content), and, in the absence of interaction, I cannot seek further understanding or clarity to cohere the various components introduced by Schonig.

However, despite this and the limited dimensionality (and the fact the video seems to cut off before the lecture is “finished”), I enjoyed the video essay simply due to a learned practice of “viewing” that comes along with ongoing film study. While a video essay doesn’t garner any sort of narrative analysis or translation of on-screen objects or geometry, it hooks the eye into it to the extent that one cannot look away or risk losing immersion in the on-screen “world”. If anything, the combination of live lecture and video essay is superior to either individually; I have used Schonig’s videos after a class or absence to further develop understanding and perspective of certain theories, and consider this multi-dimensional approach part of the “study” or “practice” necessary to the ongoing process of learning and developing mastery or competency in a topic of interest. Although, if this particular assignment were given within a traditional classroom, I would not do much differently - I sought out the writings and excerpts of the philosophers and authors mentioned in the videos, and (thankfully) have experience in using the library for research. Often within the more generalized material sourced from the library or a video, there are additional references to older or more niche sources; essentially it is like starting with a knit sweater and slowly unraveling it loop by loop, until you get to the individual yarns that forms the foundation of this larger structure. For phenomenology in particular, the average person might have to do a great deal of background research to understand the relationship of psychology to this philosophy, and if one is unfamiliar with discourse around the meaning of art or the relationship of art and viewer, it might be difficult to translate or apply to film theory. I personally chose a theory that already taps into my existing interests and experience to avoid an excess of foundational research; if given another topic, however, I would have approached it the same exact way – study the history, read the philosophy, find the first theorists who marry that philosophy with film, and reflect on my own understanding of those topics (within the

framework of the philosophy itself) to synthesize analysis.

References:

[Intro to Phenomenology and Vivian Sobchack's Film Theory](#)

Vivian Sobchack. "What My Fingers Knew: The Cinesthetic Subject, or Vision in the Flesh."

Carnal Thoughts, 1st ed., University of California Press, 2004, pp. 53-84.